shall have to deal with in the future as well, and one that the Chinese are beginning to exploit.

There are also lessons to be learned about the way that China negotiates. The Sikkim Question is a good example of how China sees others' problems as an opportunity to extract concessions or as leverage. Part of the tactic is deliberate ambiguity of position. The Chinese have developed this into a fine diplomatic tradition. The coming generations need to pay attention to what China does not say or do. The presumption that silence is acquiescence could be fatal for nations. A second takeaway is the Chinese practice of testing the Indian bottom line multiple times. China can repeat a position ad nauseam, until the other party, in sheer frustration, puts a revised offer on the table. The repetition of position at multiple meetings fulfils two objectives—it allows the Chinese to understand the time-table of the other side in resolving an issue, and it allows them to test the other side's bottom line. Both are leveraged for benefit. In the case of the Sikkim Question, the Indian bottom line remained unshakeable, but the time-table offered up the opportunity for China to secure other political objectives. It is not a pleasant situation when lack of progress leads to temporary setbacks, but this should be accepted as a part of doing diplomacy with China.

The saga of Sikkim is still not over. As China continues to progress towards becoming the world's largest economy and trading nation, the need for secure outlets to the oceans will grow. Sikkim's importance to China is growing by the day. If China can persuade India in the future to permit Chinese merchandise to transit Sikkim, it will be a 'golden goose'. It will allow China to transport goods in a secure and commercially profitably way overland through Tibet to the Indian heartland, where half a billion Indians live, thus giving it access to a major global market that is not dependent on transit through any